

Perfection and Its Problems

Suppose we allow that God is ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’. Can we unpack this concept to come to a coherent view of the divine? According to Anselm this definition entails that God must actually be *greater* than we can conceive. Doesn’t this mean that our attempt is doomed at the outset? In this chapter, after a quick sketch of how to begin the project of perfect being theology, I will discuss how it is possible for the limited creature to speak and think of the limitless creator, and then outline the list of attributes traditionally applied to ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’ with a quick explanation of why these attributes are seen as necessary to God. I shall conclude with a preview of the various problems that are raised against this picture of a perfect being in contemporary philosophy of religion.

How, then, to describe a perfect being? We can begin with two principles, which, according to the tradition, at least as developed by Aquinas, boil down to the same thing. First, as the source of all, God is *unlimited*. Any quality that would entail a limitation is to be denied of Him. Thus, for example, medieval and (most) contemporary philosophers of religion agree that God is incorporeal since being embodied is a limitation. The scope of the activity of those of us with bodies is confined to the capacities of those bodies. For example, even a body which encompassed the entire universe could not be *wholly* present everywhere at once. Any quality which is inherently limiting will be denied of God, and any perfection attributed to God will be attributed in an unlimited degree.

Interestingly, the earlier medievals seem to steer clear of using the term ‘infinite’ of God. Perhaps this is a holdover from the ancient association of

‘infinite’ with ‘incomplete’, ‘unfinished’ and hence imperfect. Anselm, writing at the end of the eleventh and beginning of the twelfth centuries uses variations on *infinitus* rarely, and does not describe the divine nature as ‘infinite’ in his philosophical works.¹ By the time of Aquinas in the mid-thirteenth century it is commonplace to speak of God as infinite in his very Being.² I shall use the term ‘infinite’ in connection with the traditional view of God, and I think it is safe to hold that, though the earlier philosophers do not use the term, this is not evidence of a fundamental shift with regard to basic beliefs about the divine nature. In *Proslogion* 20 Anselm says that God is ‘before and beyond everything’ and ‘by no means has an end’. Here he is talking mainly about God and time, but I think it is fair to say that he would agree that there is ‘no end’ to God’s wisdom, power, and so on.

A second principle, enunciated by Anselm in Chapter 5 of the *Proslogion*, is that ‘God is whatever it is better to be than not to be’. In the contemporary idiom, God must possess every ‘great-making’ property. The problem lies in deciding which properties are ‘great-making’. Both in the past, and today, the enumeration of great-making properties has proceeded largely on the basis of intuition. For example, you ‘just see’ that something possessing reason is superior to something which does not. True, the medieval philosophers in the tradition which we are drawing upon could have added that, since existence is good, the more there is to you, the better. The ability to reason adds a new dimension to the manner of one’s existing, and so rationality is a great-making property because the being with life *and* rationality has more to it than the being which is merely alive. (The notion of degrees of existence will be defended in Chapter 3.) I find this plausible and hope that our analysis of the nature of the perfect being will make this view more persuasive to the contemporary reader than it may seem at first glance, but I fear that we can never quite escape the need for intuition. This may just be the nature of things when it comes to values. If you do not see that it is better to be able to do things and to think than not, that a cat is better than a rock, and a human better than a pig, it may be difficult to convince you.³

Fortunately there is a core of agreement among the majority of philosophers of religion, medieval and contemporary. Everybody seems willing to allow that God is knowledgeable, powerful, good and a free agent. With respect to these attributes the questions that will arise will concern their scope and nature. But there are other attributes where the issue will be whether or not they should be considered ‘great-making’ properties at all. There are those who do not see any value to the traditional attributes of divine unity, eternity and immutability. Some, most notably process theologians like Charles Hartshorne, see multiplicity, temporality and

changeableness as virtues, inextricably bound up with the concept of a God who is really related to His creatures. How can such a conflict of intuitions be resolved? I shall argue for the tradition by presenting the motivation for seeing the debatable attributes as great-making properties and trying to show that, properly understood, they do not conflict with seeing God as the loving, personal being to whom we pray. I shall try to show that, while the critic of the classic tradition is right to insist that a distant and impersonal deity could not be all that our living God must be, he is wrong in failing to recognize that the classic tradition insists upon this point, as well. Throughout this discussion I will be, of necessity, working from a core of beliefs grounded in intuition, but there will still be plenty to argue about.

A perfect being, then, must have all the great-making properties and He must have them to an unlimited extent. Recently these core principles of perfect being theology have been challenged. Some contemporary philosophers of religion suggest that it is just impossible that God possess all the great-making properties in the highest possible degree. For example, there is the puzzle of whether or not God can make a being with a secret unknown even to Him. If not, He is not omnipotent. If so, He is not omniscient. We could solve the paradox by abandoning the tradition, choosing which trait is more important for a greatest possible being, knowledge or power, and just allow that God is limited with regard to the less important trait.⁴

Even setting aside the practical difficulty in deciding what degrees of which attributes are necessary to perfection, there are a number of serious problems with this approach. First, is this God adequate as the object of religious worship? Defenders of this position seem to allow, for example, that since a perfect being must be virtuous, and a virtuous being would not do bad things, God is less powerful than a being who can do both good and bad things. Surely from the religious point of view it is shocking to suggest that there could be a being more powerful than God.⁵

It could be insisted that we must accept a God who is so radically limited since this is the only way to resolve the various puzzles raised by the concept of a perfect being. I shall argue, however, that it is possible to resolve the paradoxes and leave God's infinite perfection and absolute sovereignty intact. This is important because the view that God possesses great-making properties, but to only a limited extent, entails consequences which are fundamentally at odds with the traditional understanding which insists that God is the perfectly unified and absolutely independent source of all. The tradition holds that creatures possess being and power and wisdom and justice and every other perfection because they receive them

from God. The perfections in creatures are a limited participation of the ultimate source. Though it is sometimes necessary for us to use the language of ‘having’ or ‘possessing’, God does not ‘possess’ these perfections. It is not that there is God and then, added on, various ‘perfect-making’ properties. As the absolute source and standard He just *is* all those perfections which flow forth to be reflected more or less in creatures. God is Being and Power and Wisdom and Justice, and so on. The first chapter of Anselm’s *Monologion* begins with the classic Platonic proof for God which moves from the existence of things possessing varying degrees of goodness to the existence of a source which must be maximally good, and succeeding chapters argue similarly for other perfections. In Chapter 5 of the *Proslogion*, after he has shown that ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’ must exist, he asks rhetorically, ‘Therefore what good could be lacking from this highest good, through which all goods exist?’ The Being which *is* Goodness and the source of all goodness could not ‘have’ goodness (note that in Anselm’s terms all perfections are ‘goods’) to a greater or lesser degree.

This understanding of God and His relationship to His ‘great-making’ properties and to His creation, which we will be unpacking throughout this book, is the standard medieval view of the Augustinian Neoplatonists and the more Aristotelian thinkers as well. Aquinas is adamant that God, as the first efficient cause, is pure actuality which equals absolute perfection, no lack in anything. All perfections pre-exist in God, since ‘nothing of the perfection of being can be wanting to Him Who is subsisting being itself’.⁶ He writes, quoting the Pseudo-Dionysius with approval, ‘God does not exist in a certain way; he possesses, and this before all others, all being within Himself absolutely and limitlessly’.⁷

The contemporary philosopher, of course, is free to reject the medieval approach, but one should not reject it without having at least considered it. And if one ends up deciding that Augustine and Anselm and Aquinas are fundamentally mistaken, then, in the interests of clarity, one should note that the God one has in mind is not the traditional God of the medieval philosophers. More importantly, *if* a coherent analysis of Anselm’s God, the one who just is all the ‘great-making’ properties to the highest degree, can be offered, then surely the proposed limited divinity will have to yield pride of place to it.

Throughout this book I will argue that it is the medieval approach, with its metaphysical views on the nature of the source of all, that best solves the various paradoxes raised by the notion of a perfect being. For example, on Anselm’s analysis it is immediately obvious that God, though omnipotent, cannot make someone who possesses a secret unknown to Him. Anselm’s

solution to the puzzle lies in an understanding of divine simplicity, so I will save consideration of it until the next chapter. Suffice it to say here that this divine ‘inability’ does not limit God’s omnipotence in the least.

‘That than which a greater cannot be conceived’ is limitless, and possesses all the great-making properties to the highest degree or infinitely. In the traditional view, God, as source, actually *is* the perfections in question, and is all of them in a perfectly unified way. But now we are confronted with a perennial problem in the philosophy of religion. God is a very different sort of being from those with which we are usually concerned. How do our words apply to God? The medievals devoted a great deal of thought to this question and suggested a variety of sophisticated answers which form the foundation of the discussion to the present day.⁸ To my knowledge the solutions they offered have not been superseded by any new and improved versions, so a quick canvas of the most viable of the medieval analyses of religious language should provide us with enough background to proceed.

Plotinus calls the source of all the One, and sees it as so transcendent that it is beyond all positive terms, even Being. In answer to the question of how we can speak of or describe such a thing, he responds, ‘We can’t.’ We can seek union with the One in a mystical vision beyond reason, but we cannot talk about it. The philosophers of the Book could not go this route. The Bible speaks of God and insists that we do so in our forms of worship. We must apply our language to God. The question is, what do our terms *mean*.

Maimonides, the great twelfth-century Jewish philosopher, agrees that we must use the words employed in our sacred writing, but we do not use them to describe God positively as He is in Himself. God is absolute unity and completely unrelated to His creation. Maimonides explains in Chapter 52 of Book I of his *Guide for the Perplexed* that the tradition legitimates the application of certain terms to God, but the meaning of these terms must be negative or causal. Thus when we say that, ‘God is good’, we may mean, negatively, that He is not bad. It is not that God is like the goodness that we know, only much more so. ‘Good’ simply means not bad. It does not tell us anything positive at all about what God is like. On Maimonides’ causal analysis, terms applied to God mean to indicate what He has caused. That is, to say that ‘God is good’ is to say that He is the cause of good things, but Maimonides insists that we cannot move from the effect to saying anything at all about the nature of the cause. Maimonides’ analysis of biblical language leaves us unable to talk about God as He is.

This seems a very difficult position for the believer who is commanded to love and worship the Lord. How can we love something if we have no idea at all of what it is? As Aquinas notes, these purely negative or causal

meanings are certainly not what we ordinarily intend when we speak of God. And if all attributes had a merely negative or causal meaning then any term would be as appropriate as any other. The term 'body' would be as apt as the term 'good' with respect to God since all we could mean by 'God is body' is 'He is not pure potentiality' or 'He is the cause of bodies'. Both of these statements are as correct as the purely negative or causal meanings of 'God is good', that is, 'God is not bad' and 'God is the cause of good things'.⁹

Fortunately for the future of perfect being theology, there do seem to be adequate ways of bridging the gulf between creature and creator and solving the problem of religious language. Here we can look only very briefly at three suggestions, rooted in the three different epistemologies of Anselm, Aquinas and Duns Scotus. (Scotus was a fourteenth-century philosopher who, though he sometimes used the thought of Aristotle, defended certain theses central to the Augustinian tradition, like extreme realism, the self-evidence of God and the possibility of univocal predication. We will see in Chapter 7 that he departs from both the Augustinians and the Aristotelians in his acceptance of voluntarism.) Anselm argues that we can speak of God univocally, that is, the words we use of God have the same meaning as when we use them of creatures. True, God and creatures are very different, but if a term is properly applicable to both then its significance must be sufficiently general to span the gap. An elephant is very different from a gnat, but the term 'animal' is applied univocally to both.¹⁰ And this position follows directly from his metaphysics and epistemology. Anselm's thought falls squarely in the tradition of Augustinian Neoplatonism in which the basic relationship of creation to Creator is one of participation, and the most fundamental epistemic fact is divine illumination.

Participation means that every good quality which is possessed by a creature is possessed through some sort of 'reflecting' or 'sharing in' the nature of the divine. The relationship is closer than that of copies to the original blueprint or mirror images to the object reflected but stops short, *well* short, of identity. The divine transcends its created image even as it pervades it. If this all sounds too vague and metaphorical, the Platonist can respond that it is just very difficult to describe a causal relationship which is *sui generis* and in which the cause is God. For the purposes of the analysis of religious language, the important feature is that it is in fact the same perfection which creatures reflect and which God just *is*.

Although the perfections in question are not sensible qualities, they have no color or smell, and so on, we can recognize them in creatures because we have received knowledge directly from the source of all through divine

illumination. We recognize wisdom and justice and goodness in things because we already have the idea of them in our minds, 'implanted' by God. Because of this inner knowledge we can appreciate goodness *per se* and hence apply the term 'good' to the creature in which it exists as limited and reflected and to the Creator in which it exists as identical with His nature. Anselm is adamant that the terms we use of the perfections in God and creatures are sufficiently general to cover both the unlimited cause and the created effects.¹¹

Aquinas has a more difficult task when it comes to defending the view that we can speak positively, not just causally or negatively, of God's nature, 'substantially' in Thomas's terms. He insists that, barring a miracle, all our knowledge, beliefs, concepts and so on begin with experience. We have no immediate experience of God. Our understanding of the terms we use for God is drawn from our observation of creatures. But if God is infinite and perfectly unified, how could our concept of an attribute, derived from the limited creature, be properly applied to God? It cannot be applied univocally, Aquinas holds, but nonetheless we can speak properly and substantially of God so long as we recognize that our language applies analogically.

In analyzing the signification of an attributive term there are two things to be considered. There is the *res significata*, the very attribute signified, and there is the *modus significandi*, the way in which the term can be applied to the particular kind of thing in question. According to Aquinas when we use a term of very different kinds of things, the *modus significandi* changes, and so the meaning cannot be exactly the same. Thus when we say, 'The dog is good' and 'God is good' the *res significata* of the term 'good' is the same, it is goodness. We are justified in ascribing the same attribute to God and the creature because of the causal relationship between the two.¹² However, because God is infinite and unified the *modus significandi* of a term applied to God and creatures is different. We cannot possibly comprehend just *how* God is good, and so although we do have an understanding of goodness, there is inevitably a vagueness and inadequacy when we use the term of the perfect being. Contemporary philosophers of religion can exploit this insistence upon the inadequacy of our concepts when applied to God to explain why it may be impossible to express certain difficult positions with perfect clarity. Care must be taken, though, to retain the notion that there is some sameness of significance when we apply our empirically grounded terms to God. Just how Thomas himself balanced the sameness and the difference, and how they ought to be balanced, are the subject of debate among contemporary students of Aquinas.¹³

Scotus, writing in the fourteenth century, offers an interesting reconciliation between Anselm's doctrine of univocity and Aquinas' epistemology. Scotus agrees with the Aristotelians that we learn through abstraction from sense data. The question is, what exactly is the content of our abstracted concept? Aquinas held that our understanding of the meaning of the term 'good' must inevitably involve goodness as it exists in creatures. Hence we can speak of God only analogically. Scotus disagrees. He argues that in order for us to speak properly of God, there must be some underlying sameness, genuinely applicable to the creature and God, which we are capable of grasping. For example, God is not good as a dog is good. If we cannot move beyond understanding 'good' except insofar as it applies to the dog and other good creatures, then we cannot properly use the term of God. Fortunately, though our concepts are produced by abstraction from sense data, we are capable of abstracting concepts of sufficient generality that they can apply univocally to God and creatures. We get our concept of wisdom, for example, from observing creatures. In creatures wisdom is limited. Wisdom *per se*, however, is neither limited nor unlimited. Wisdom is just wisdom. When we abstract the concept we can strip it, *in intellectu*, of all the imperfections which accompany wisdom in the creature but which are not part of the definition of 'wisdom'. Thus we come to a concept of perfect and unlimited wisdom, the wisdom of God. This is not to say that the limited knower can fully comprehend what it is to be perfectly wise. We cannot imagine or somehow 'picture' perfect wisdom, what it is like to be perfectly wise, but we can grasp the concept 'perfect wisdom' enough to apply it properly to God.¹⁴ To borrow an analogous example from Anselm, though by definition we cannot comprehend an ineffable being, we nonetheless understand the term 'ineffable'.¹⁵ Among contemporary philosophers of religion William Alston argues for this Scotist approach.¹⁶ The practice of religion demands that we be able to speak and think about God, and there are systematic philosophical analyses which suggest ways in which this can be done. Anselm and Scotus are perhaps a bit more optimistic than Aquinas, but even the analogical approach insists that we can speak literally and positively about God. From this point on I shall take it that when we apply attributes to God we are speaking of God Himself and we know (albeit in a limited or perhaps analogical way) what we are talking about.

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It will be useful now to sketch the great-making properties which 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived' must possess. (I do not claim that this list is exhaustive.) There is an important reason for this. We limited and temporal creatures must examine these attributes piecemeal. In God they are one and identical to His nature. If one tries to analyze one

attribute in isolation from the rest one inevitably fails to comprehend it properly. Too often contemporary analytic philosophy of religion works to solve this or that puzzle concerning some attribute of God but fails to take into account the relationship (that is, identity) of the attributes to one another and to God. I hope to minimize the problem by offering an outline of the key great-making properties which the reader can keep in mind as we work through the individual properties in detail in the rest of this book. This should enable us to approach perfect being theology more as a systematic whole, than as a series of isolated problems. I will conclude the chapter by noting a number of problems that will be raised against this Anselmian conception of God.

A great-making property which the classic tradition viewed as perhaps the most important, certainly non-negotiable, and which many contemporary analytic philosophers of religion seem content to jettison is simplicity. (The more detailed analysis of divine simplicity will entail that terms like 'property', 'attribute' and their synonyms are not accurate without serious qualification. Let them stand for now, in the interests of expediency.) God is perfect unity. This is the attribute to which Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae*, moves immediately upon having proved the existence of God. And, contrary to Peter Geach's interpretation, when Aquinas says that God is 'one' he certainly does not mean just that there are not several Gods.¹⁷ In that case one might as well say that Peter Geach possesses simplicity just as God does, since there are not many Peter Geaches. What Aquinas means is that there is absolutely no multiplicity or composition in God. All the qualities which we attribute to God are identical to one another and to God Himself.

Why say this? Anselm's argument is simple. It is a weakness to be corruptible. Anything that can be taken apart is corruptible. Anything made of parts can be taken apart, if not in reality at least *in intellectu*. So if God were thought to be composite, we could think of His destruction. But then we could think of something greater, an absolutely indestructible being. QED.¹⁸ Aquinas goes down the list of the various ways in which something could be composite, and shows that each of them involves the composite being in some sort of limitation or dependence on something else. So the perfect being must transcend all multiplicity, even that of a duality between essence and existence. God just *is* His very act of existing.¹⁹ I will defend this difficult doctrine in the next chapter. Once the doctrine of divine simplicity can be appreciated and embraced, many of the apparent paradoxes raised against the Anselmian conception of God can be resolved.

God's essence (nature) is to exist, which is to say that He is a necessary

being. If He exists then He *must* exist. Whether or not this entails that His non-existence is unthinkable, as Anselm argues, has been the subject of debate for the past 900 years. Another way of arguing for divine necessity is from God's absolute independence. In the classic tradition individual things are either necessary or contingent (with various possible qualifications in either case), and to be contingent is to be caused and dependent, since for anything that might or might not exist, an explanation is required for its being there at all. Whether or not contingent things require causal explanations is one of those perennial debates in modern philosophy, but contemporary philosophers of religion seem to accept the judgement of their predecessors that God must be uncaused and that it is greater to exist necessarily (one current way to put it is, 'God must exist in all possible worlds') than contingently.

Contemporary philosophers have been less willing to accept the tradition's insistence that God be immutable. According to Augustine and Anselm and Aquinas God does not change. This does not mean just that God's basic nature remains the same while His knowledge and activities can differ over time. Anselm's God is perfectly simple. His knowledge and activities are one with His nature. For God to come to know something or to do this and then that would be for Him to change in His very being. And that is quite impossible. God is the absolute best. He 'possesses' all the great-making properties to the highest degree. If He were to change He could only become a lesser being. In this traditional view of perfection there is no room for lateral motion. But if He *could* become a lesser being, He is corruptible. And if He is corruptible He is not 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived'. The God of the classic tradition does not and 'could not' change.

Not only is God immutable, He is also impassive. He does not suffer pain or sorrow. Augustine and Aquinas even seem to hold that God is not at all affected by human activities. Augustine argues from God's omnipotence that nothing happens in the world which is not entirely under God's control. Aquinas defends divine impassivity by pointing out that if God, as the best, is pure actuality, there can be no unrealized potential in Him. For us to act upon God would be for us to produce in Him some motion from potential to actual, which is absurd. Obviously there are difficulties here for the believer in a loving God. It may be possible, within Thomas's metaphysics, to reconcile God as a pure act of being with the loving Father who answers prayers. In any case the tradition does offer another approach in the work of Anselm who insists not only that God does but also that there is a sense in which He *must* respond to the actions of His creatures.

Another divine attribute which most of the medievals accepted and which many contemporary philosophers reject is eternity. It is not enough to say that God is everlasting, that is that He has always existed in the past and will always exist in the future. God is eternal. He is outside of time. All of time is immediately present to God but He is not temporal. There are a number of reasons for saying this. For one thing, to be temporal is to change. A genuinely immutable being does not change even with respect to temporal location. God is unlimited. To be temporal is to exist only in this present instant, this extensionless point where the yet-to-exist future becomes the gone-forever past. The only bit of our lives to which we temporal beings have access or which we have power over is this almost non-existent present slice. God, in contrast, possesses all of Himself at once and has access to and power over everything, everywhere, always. As absolute source of all, God must transcend the limitations of His creation. The medieval philosophers and the contemporary physicists tell us that time and space are categories of the physical universe, ways of describing the relationships between physical beings. God, as creator, cannot be bound by the categories He has made. (That God is non-physical has not been questioned by the orthodox, medieval or modern, and so we will spend almost no time in defending what no one disputes.) Seeing God as eternal solves a number of apparent paradoxes. How could an immutable being also be a creator? By doing all He does immutably in His eternal 'now'. How could God know future free choices? By 'seeing' them from His eternal 'present' as they are being made.

The attributes of omnipotence, omniscience and omnibenevolence have been less controversial than the ones listed above. Almost everyone agrees that it is best for God to be as knowledgeable as possible and as powerful as possible. And no one doubts that 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived' must be *very* good in some sense of 'good' related to moral goodness. This last attribute raises the very difficult problem of why a good God permits evil, but no one doubts that goodness must be among the qualities of God. The problems with the knowledge, power and goodness of God arise as a result of the paradoxes generated when we try to analyze just what they entail and especially when we ascribe them all to the same being. Finally, everyone engaged in the project of perfect being theology agrees that God is the Creator of our world. Almost everyone holds that He is a person who creates through a free act of will. Again the questions revolve around just what this entails, and how to view God's creative activity in the light of all the other attributes ascribed to Him.

The objections raised against this conception of God are legion. Here let me offer a quick preview of the sort of problems to expect. It is common

nowadays to hold that some of the great-making properties are inherently incoherent. Swinburne, for example, dismisses the idea that God is eternal, saying that he ‘cannot make much sense of this suggestion’. (And he is content with the corollary ‘refinement’ of God’s omniscience which involves denying divine foreknowledge, since a temporal God can’t know future free choices.)²⁰ The doctrine of divine simplicity has been widely repudiated since it is taken to mean that, if God just *is* His goodness, knowledge and so on then He is a property. And it makes no sense to hold that a person is a property.

A second sort of criticism involves the view that attributes ascribed to God are mutually inconsistent. Here are a few examples. A simple being cannot know and do many things, as required by omniscience, omnipotence and creativity. An eternal being cannot know what time it is now, and hence cannot be omniscient. A necessarily good being could not do evil, and hence could not be omnipotent. No being could be both omniscient and omnipotent since an omnipotent being could make a creature who had a secret unknown to anyone but itself, while an omniscient being must know every secret. We can defend God’s goodness only by holding that He could not prevent the evil choices of His free creatures, but if our choices are outside of God’s control then He is not omnipotent. If God is morally good, then He must choose freely, but if He is necessarily the best then He cannot do other than the best, so God is not morally good. And what sense does it make to speak of ‘choice’ at all, in the case of an eternal and immutable being?

A third difficulty was noted at the end of the last chapter. Even supposing we can make sense of the great-making properties and show them to be mutually consistent, won’t the concept of God at which we arrive be so distant from religious experience as to be . . . useless? What relevance could this eternal, immutable, impassive being have to us? This transcendent stranger can hardly be supposed to listen to our prayers. For us, what difference does it make whether or not such a being exists? This is a criticism that is often raised against the Anselmian approach, and I shall attempt to answer it throughout this work. Here suffice it to say that God’s love, to be treated under the headings of ‘Goodness’ and ‘Creation’, is as necessary a property as any other. God cares about you and me, He listens to our prayers . . . and He does it impassively, immutably and eternally.

NOTES

1. See Gillian Evans (ed.), *A Concordance to the Works of St. Anselm*.
2. For a discussion of this change in attitude towards *infinitus* see Leo Sweeney, *Divine Infinity in Greek and Medieval Thought*, pp. 319–36.
3. I do make some attempt in ‘The medieval approach to aardvarks, escalators and God’.

4. This is the approach taken by George Schlesinger in *New Perspectives on Old-Time Religion*. He presents the 'unknown secret' example in 'Divine Perfection'.
5. See, for example, Melissa Franklin, 'The indispensability of the single-divine-attribute doctrine', p. 434.
6. ST I, Q.IV, art.2.
7. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentiles* (henceforth SCG) Book I, Chapter 28, 9 (I am following the translation of Anton C. Pegis, University of Notre Dame edition).
8. Much of the modern discussion is carried on among Thomists (followers of Thomas Aquinas) and those conversant with the Thomistic approach like James Ross, *Portraying Analogy*. Among other contemporary philosophers of religion, it is probably William Alston who offers the most sustained discussion of religious language. In his *Divine Nature and Human Language* he argues for speaking about God literally, as opposed to metaphorically (pp. 17–63) and suggests how to go about doing so (pp. 64–102).
9. ST I, Q.XIII, art.2.
10. Anselm makes this case in discussing 'freedom' in *On the Freedom of the Will* 1 and 'justice' in *On Truth* 12.
11. See Chapter 5 of my *Neoplatonic Metaphysics and Epistemology of Anselm of Canterbury*.
12. See John Wippel, 'Thomas Aquinas and participation'.
13. See W. Norris Clarke, 'Analogy and the meaningfulness of language about God'; Ralph McInerny, *Studies in Analogy*; James Ross, 'Analogy as a rule of meaning for religious language'; John F. Wippel, 'Thomas Aquinas on what philosophers can know about God'.
14. Duns Scotus, *Oxford Commentary on the Four Books of the Sentences*, Book I, Distinction III, Questions 1 and 2.
15. Anselm, *Response to Gaunilo* IX.
16. William Alston, 'Aquinas on theological predication', p. 175.
17. Peter Geach, 'The meaning of 'God' – II', p. 87.
18. Anselm, *Proslogion* 18.
19. ST I, Q.3, art.7.
20. Richard Swinburne, *Is There a God?*, pp. 8–9.

Divine Simplicity

Thomas Aquinas, in his *Summa Theologiae*, having proved the existence of God, moves at once to proving His simplicity.¹ For the first two thousand years of Western philosophy, just about everybody, from Parmenides on, who argues that there is a perfect source of all, argues that that source is absolutely unified. To be composite or complex in any way at all is to be limited. And the unity in question is more than just a lack of parts, corporeal or incorporeal. The perfect being of the Western tradition is so simple that He cannot be said even to 'have' a number of individual qualities. The classic tradition identifies God with His attributes and identifies each attribute with the rest. Thus Augustine in *The City of God* XI, 10 says that whatever a simple being has it just *is*. Anselm entitles Chapter 16 of the *Monologion*,

That it is the same for [the Supreme Being] to be just, as it is for it to be justice; and the same for those other things that can similarly be said of it; and that none of these show how it is or how much it is (*qualis . . . vel quanta*), but what it is.

And Aquinas writes (ST I, Q.3, art.3), 'He must be His own Godhead, His own Life, and whatever else is so predicated of Him.' Strictly speaking, God is not (for example) wise, and powerful and good. He is Wisdom and Power and Goodness, and the three are identical.

Many contemporary analytic philosophers of religion have found this view of God's nature radically implausible.² This may be due in part to the fact that the traditional concept has been almost universally misunderstood in the present debate. Even those who defend a doctrine of divine simplicity

almost always fail to present it in the powerful version expressed best by Aquinas, but found very clearly in earlier thinkers like Anselm.³ The mistake is in failing to see that God is not a property but an act. In this chapter I will present some motivations for accepting the doctrine of divine simplicity, look at some contemporary criticisms, and show how the traditional doctrine does not fall prey to them. I shall try to mitigate the doctrine's *prima facie* bizarreness through analogies with human experience. Even if I succeed in making the traditional view seem plausible, there are difficult corollaries. It will prove worthwhile to explore ways in which the difficulties can be minimized because the doctrine of simplicity plays a vital role in perfect being theology and should not be abandoned except at the greatest need.

Why adopt the doctrine of divine simplicity? A perfect being must be unlimited, but to be composite or complex is to be limited. There are some sorts of composition where this is easily seen, and no one debates about it. One of the reasons to deny corporeality to God is that to be a body is to be composed of extended material parts, and so to be divisible and hence destructible.⁴ No one, classical or contemporary, argues that God is a corporeal being. The classic position, though, goes far beyond a mere denial of divine corporeality and insists that there is no multiplicity of any kind in God. Why say this?

In Chapter 2 I mentioned Anselm's short argument from *Proslogion* 18 that if God can be thought to have any sort of parts at all then He can be thought to be corruptible, at least *in intellectu*. Thus we can think of a better being, one who cannot be dismantled even in the mind, and hence that than which a greater cannot be conceived must be completely simple. This probably strikes the modern reader as far too quick, especially as a 'proof' for a view which many find so counterintuitive.

An argument which seems to resonate much more powerfully today is the one drawn from divine aseity. In order to be perfect God must not depend for His existence on anything else. He must exist absolutely *a se*, from Himself. But if we posit that God *has* the properties of (for example) wisdom, power and goodness, and indeed *must* have them in order to exist as God, but we hold that these are not identical with Him, then are we not forced to the conclusion that God's existence is dependent upon things other than Himself? Anselm, in the *Monologion*, casts this argument in the Platonic mold.⁵ Aquinas makes roughly the same argument in the *Summa Theologiae* (I Q.3, art.7) and Brian Leftow presents a very persuasive contemporary version.⁶ Even those who reject the doctrine of divine simplicity feel the force of the argument. Plantinga writes,

Now I think the intuition – call it the sovereignty-aseity intuition – underlying the doctrine of divine simplicity must be taken with real seriousness. Suppose God has essentially the property of being omnipotent and suppose that property is an object distinct from him, is uncreated by him and exists necessarily. Then in some sense he does depend on that property. For in the first place he could not have existed if it had not; its existence is a necessary condition of his existence. And secondly he couldn't have the character he does have, couldn't be the way he is, if omnipotence didn't exist or weren't the way it is.⁷

Plantinga finds what he calls the 'Thomist' doctrine of divine simplicity unacceptable, and concludes that God does not exist absolutely *a se*.⁸

Aseity and simplicity are important, not only intrinsically, but also because they can help solve other puzzles. For example, consider the problem Plato raises in the *Euthyphro*. Is the good whatever God wills, or does God will what He wills because it is good? If the former, ethics seems to be a matter of arbitrary, if divine, fiat. But if the latter there is an ethical code external to God to which He must conform to be good. (He does not exist *a se* with respect to his goodness.) The doctrine of simplicity solves the problem. God neither obeys the moral order, nor does He invent it. He is Goodness Itself, and all else that is good is good in imitation of God's nature.

A parallel argument can be made for the logician's version of the *Euthyphro* dilemma. God neither invented nor is He bound by modal truths. What must be, what can be, and what cannot be all reflect God's nature which is Perfect Being Itself. If the realm of possibilities is not somehow dependent on God, and this seems to be Plantinga's conclusion, then the existence of the Judeo-Christian God as the creator *ex nihilo* is called into question.⁹ This argument goes back at least to Ockham who opted for nominalism, denying that realm of possibilities rather than denying creation *ex nihilo*.¹⁰ If one feels committed to the doctrine of creation *ex nihilo*, and if one finds nominalism metaphysically unappealing, one had better reconsider the traditional doctrine of simplicity.

There are, as we shall see, a number of other puzzles which this classic view of the nature of God solves. Moreover it plays an important role in a number of theological arguments. A case can be made that in the work of Aquinas it is the doctrine of simplicity which drives the arguments for God's various (ultimately identical) attributes in the subsequent articles of the *Summa Theologiae*.¹¹ The doctrine plays an important role in Aquinas' cosmological arguments.¹² And contemporary philosophers of religion have used it in cosmological and ontological arguments.¹³ But if the doctrine of divine simplicity is intrinsically incoherent or inconsistent

with other things we must say about a perfect being then we will have to abandon it.

There are a number of problems which contemporary philosophers of religion raise against the doctrine of divine simplicity. Alvin Plantinga offers a succinct and vivid critique of the doctrine of simplicity in *Does God Have a Nature?*

There are two difficulties, one substantial and the other truly monumental. In the first place if God is identical with each of his properties, then each of his properties is identical with each of his properties, so that God has but one property. This seems flatly incompatible with the obvious fact that God has several properties; he has both power and mercifulness, say, neither of which is identical with the other. In the second place, if God is identical with each of his properties, then, since each of his properties is a property, he is a property – a self-exemplifying property. Accordingly God has just one property: himself. This view is subject to a difficulty both obvious and overwhelming. No property could have created the world; no property could be omniscient, or indeed, know anything at all. If God is a property, then he isn't a person but a mere abstract object; he has no knowledge, awareness, power, love or life. So taken, the simplicity doctrine seems an utter mistake.¹⁴

Most of the contemporary debate has centered around the questions of whether or not God could be a property, and whether or not all His properties could be identical.¹⁵ For example, it has been argued that God is not identical with wisdom or justice *per se*, but with *his own* instance of these properties. In creatures wisdom and justice are not identical, but it does not follow that *God's* wisdom might not be identical with *God's* justice.¹⁶ This cannot be the position of the perfect being theologian since if God's justice is held to be merely one (albeit perfect and infinite) instance of justice, then God does not exist absolutely *a se*. His existence depends in some way on there being justice for Him to exemplify. The classic tradition holds that as absolute source God is indeed Wisdom and Justice and Goodness *per se*, and other things possess these qualities through participation in the divine.

The major problem with the contemporary debate is that almost all participants misunderstand the classic doctrine of simplicity.¹⁷ The medieval view, spelled out most clearly by Aquinas, but certainly there in Anselm, is that, strictly speaking God neither *has* properties nor *is* He a property . . . however unified and exalted. God is simply act.¹⁸ As Aquinas sees it, striving for perfection is the same as actualizing potentials, so

something which is absolutely perfect is something which is fully actualized, wholly in act.¹⁹ This is what it means to say that God's essence just is His existence, and that His very nature is Perfect Being. Existence is not an inert property. It is an act, the act of being. Unhampered by any limitation, God is Pure Act. I fear that the modern reader is inclined to find this concept quite opaque. If we describe God as simply His act of existing, then is not this the most limited, 'thinnest' possible conception of divinity?²⁰ Isn't existence an on/off property shared by everything that is, and not possessed in varying degrees?²¹

The mistake here is a confusion between being-in-general with perfect being. Being-in-general is the being, the bare existence, that any existent has in order to exist. And conceptually it is exceedingly 'thin'. Aquinas himself raises a similar point as an objection against his view that God is Pure Being. Aquinas, in fact, carries the criticism several steps further and submits that if we identify God with being-in-general we end with pantheism and attributing radical imperfection to God.²² What 'Pure Being' meant for Aquinas was not 'bare existence', but rather 'existence in the most perfect way possible'. (In the present discussion it makes no difference whether or not we call God 'Pure Being' or '*the* Pure Being'. However the latter is permissible only with the qualifications that [1] God exists 'more fully' than other beings precisely because He is the perfect existence which they reflect and [2] God, as I shall argue below, is a being who is an *act*.) Pure Being is being freed from all limitations, that is, possessing all perfections. It is act without any hindrance of potential. Is corporeality an imperfection? Then Pure Being is incorporeal. And this is not a 'limitative' or negative attribute since it is embodiment which places a limitation on being. Is it better absolutely to be animate than inanimate? Then God is alive. Is, as the Philosopher says, thinking the best activity? Then God is rational. Is it better to be a person, than not?

Now the nature which *person* includes in its definition is of all natures the most exalted, to wit that nature which is intellectual in regard to its genus. Likewise the mode of existence signified by the word *person* is most exalted, namely that a thing exists by itself. Since then whatsoever is most excellent in creatures should be attributed to God, it is becoming that the word *person* should be attributed to God, even as other terms which are said of God properly.²³

If it is argued that we add to the notion of being when we say that it is incorporeal, living, rational and the rest, this is true of being-in-general, the on/off property which can be attributed to all existent things finite and infinite. In the same way we add to the notion of being-in-general when we

describe an existent thing as material, canine or white. When Aquinas identifies God with Being He is speaking of Infinite Being, Perfect Act with no limitations.

An analogy may help. (It is intended only to give an impression of the difference between a superior and an inferior version of the same nature, where the superior version is simply fulfilling its nature while the inferior version is made inferior through the addition of limitations. It fails to capture the crucially important causal relationship between Pure Being and the being-in-general of creatures.) Imagine a healthy oak tree growing under ideal circumstances, trunk as tall as an oak's can be, roots and branches spreading far and wide. Call this the Pure Oak. Now imagine a bonsai oak, its roots in a small pot, its trunk wrapped, its branches held down by wires. It has achieved its full growth and is eleven inches tall. Both trees possess oakness-in-general, but the Pure Oak has fully actualized its nature. It is not suffering under the limitations imposed on the bonsai oak. We might say that it possesses the perfections of not-pottedness, not-trunk-wrappedness and not-branches-wiredness, but these are not really additions to the oakness. The Pure Oak has oakness as it exists in an ideal situation and sans limitations. It is the bonsai oak which has all the additional properties and it is made smaller by them. Both trees have oakness-in-general, but it makes sense to distinguish between the oakness of any oak, and the Pure Oakness possessed only by the fully actualized specimen. Similarly it is legitimate to distinguish being-in-general from Pure Being.²⁴

The doctrine of simplicity is not subject to the criticism that God is some sort of inert property, with all the difficulties that entails. Nor does the point about the 'thinness' of Aquinas' concept of Being Itself hit the mark, since Aquinas explicitly distinguishes being-in-general from God's perfect mode of existing. So when Aquinas (or, I take it, Anselm or Augustine) says that God is His omnipotence, omniscience, omnibenevolence and so on and that all of these are identical with God, what He means is that God is His act of knowing and doing and being perfectly good and these are all one act. At this point even someone inclined to give Aquinas every benefit of the doubt may feel that we have not really made much progress. We are still confronted with extremely difficult questions, of which the first is: How can God, Who is a person, possibly be an act?

It seems obvious that a person cannot be an action. But perhaps this point becomes less apparent if we look carefully at human experience. Odd as it seems to call David Hume as a witness for the defense here, the radical empiricists seem to be correct when they point out that all we can experience of ourselves, apart from our perceptions of our bodies, is our own acting and experiencing.²⁵ We do not experience ourselves as

having properties underlying the activities. I do not, for example, have any perception of my own rationality as a property, except in that I experience myself thinking. I do not perceive my *ability* to write except in that I experience or remember the activity of writing. All we perceive is our acting, our thinking, our feeling, our perceiving. And all of these are basically actions. Or, if this seems to be too broad a use of the term 'action', at least these are much more like things we do than like properties we have. Those of us who reject radical empiricism hypothesize some one thing which does our acting and thinking and so on, a unifying self underlying our various experiences, because we see that if there is no unity somehow 'beneath' the diverse many then we as individuals do not really exist. But in terms of what we can know of ourselves through introspection, we are really rather more like actions than not. We do not hypothesize any unity underlying the diversity in God because there is no diversity. There is just the one, perfect act which is God. In order to make the traditional doctrine of simplicity somewhat more comprehensible, it is only necessary to show that in human experience there is some analogue for a person who is an act. Since what we perceive of ourselves is act, or at least active, the analogy is not hard to find.²⁶

It might be argued that even if we can make some sense of the notion that God is act, this does not solve the problem of multiplicity since clearly God knows and does all sorts of different things. The classic tradition responds that both God and the solution to this problem are simple. God knows all He knows in a single act. Aquinas systematizes this view nicely when he explains that God knows all things in knowing Himself, because in knowing Himself He knows the myriad ways in which He could be imitated.²⁷ And He does all He does in a single act. Again the analogy with human experience is not hard to find. Suppose *you* know that Anselm was born in 1033. This single piece of knowledge incorporates various bits of information; who Anselm was, what it is to be born, what '1033' means. Suppose *you* are writing about Anselm. This single act incorporates looking at the screen, pressing the keys, and thinking. The limited human being is able to incorporate a lot of information in a single piece of knowledge and to accomplish various things in a single act. So is God, only much more so.²⁸ If it is insisted that this still ascribes to God a sort of complexity or multiplicity, if knowing everything and doing everything in one, single act is insufficiently simple, then the only alternative seems to be Plotinus' approach in which God is so unified that He doesn't exactly know or do anything. This move is not open to Christian orthodoxy, and the Thomistic version of the doctrine will prove adequate to the demands of God's perfect aseity.²⁹

The question remains: How could all of the attributes we must ascribe to God possibly be identical? I take it that if a plausible case can be made that God's omniscience, omnipotence and omnibenevolence are the same act, this entails the likelihood that anything we want to say about God can be identified with this act. And in fact, in the classic tradition, the identification of God's knowledge with His power went without saying. How would an incorporeal person act *except* through thinking? When the medievals read in Genesis that in the beginning God said, 'Let there be light', they took God's 'speaking' to be thinking. And when they read at the beginning of John's Gospel that it was through the Word that all things were made, they again understood the Word, the Second Person of the Trinity, to be *logos*, *ratio*, the thinking of God.³⁰ And on the human level there is at the very least a close correlation between power and knowledge, in that in the vast majority of cases being able to do something requires, on some level, knowing *how* to do it.

We will analyze omniscience and omnipotence in Chapters 6 and 7 respectively. Here I will just point out that the doctrine of simplicity can solve a paradox raised in the contemporary debate over the nature of God. Could God make a creature which has a secret unknown even to Him? If not, He is not omnipotent. If so, He is not omniscient. But given the doctrine of divine simplicity the paradox cannot arise. In the classic tradition, God's omnipotence entails that everything that has any sort of being at all, besides God, is kept in existence from moment to moment by God's causal power. Since God's power is His knowledge, whatever is *is* because it is being thought right now by God. To hypothesize something which exists on its own not immediately caused by God's thought is to deny God's omnipotence. However we define a secret, it is some sort of a 'thing' either physical or mental. Neither the knower nor the secret could exist if it were unknown to God. So if there were a secret unknown to God, not only would He not be omniscient, He would not be omnipotent either. For God to make someone with a secret unknown even to Him would be to shed both His omniscience and His omnipotence, which is impossible. As we shall see in Chapter 7, omnipotence does not entail an ability to do the impossible. And, according to the classic tradition, a contingent existent unknown and hence uncaused by God is quite impossible. God is omniscient and omnipotent . . . and from Him no secrets are hid.

But could the power and wisdom of God be the same as God's goodness? In human experience power and goodness seem to be quite different phenomena. Stalin or Mao, in engineering the deaths of innocent millions, seem to express the epitome of earthly power. Mother Theresa, tending the poorest of the poor, is surely good. And there does not seem to be much common ground between them. In the final analysis, though, it is Mother

Theresa who better exemplifies the sort of power God has. I will have much more to say on the nature of divine power later, but here suffice it to say that in the classic tradition God's omnipotence does not mean the ability to do anything logically possible. God does not do evil. All that *is* is good and is kept in being by God. Evil is the corruption and negation and destruction of the good . . . what Stalin and Mao were so adept at.³¹ But this is the opposite of the creative and productive power of God. The human analogue for divine power is the ability to behave productively and beneficially. And in the classic tradition which we are considering this is what it means to be good. (Notice that at work here is a particular view on value in general which, when spelled out in connection with morality, is known as 'Natural Law Ethics'. I will discuss this ethical system in connection with the goodness of God in Chapter 9.) Even on the human level, goodness, power (of the positive sort) and wisdom are very closely interrelated. Subtract from these properties any creaturely limitations and they become one perfectly good, thinking act: God.

I have tried to meet some of the current criticisms of the doctrine of divine simplicity by pointing out that God, in the traditional view, is not considered a property at all, but an act. And sense can be made of the view that the things we want to say about God, such as that He is wise and powerful and good, can all refer to this act. Some very difficult problems remain. First, the doctrine of simplicity entails a position which many contemporary philosophers of religion find incoherent, and that is that God is eternal. He is literally outside of time. We must say this if we are to identify God with His act of being, for if He were temporal He would do first one thing then another. But if His essence is identical with what He does, then He would become a different being as He did different things. If we were to posit some unity underlying but separate from these changing acts we would thereby abandon the doctrine of simplicity. We can solve the problem by saying that God does not change. Rather, He does all He does in one, eternal act. I shall defend the ascription of eternity to a perfect being in Chapter 5. Here there are even more difficult problems to attend to.

It seems that there are all sorts of contingent truths about God. If He created freely, then He might not have done so, and that God is a creator is a contingent truth. If I am writing freely, then I might not have written, and so 'God knows that Rogers is writing' is a contingent truth. But if God's power and His knowledge are identical to the eternal act of being which is His nature, how could He do and know other than He does and knows without being other than God? (The way the question is usually phrased in the contemporary debate has to do with whether or not God's contingent properties could somehow be identical to His necessary properties.)

In the medieval tradition we are considering, Augustine, Anselm and Aquinas each offer different answers to the question about God's contingent attributes. (I do not claim that these exhaust the medieval approaches to the problem.) The different answers become clearer if we look first at the question of divine choice, and then move to the related issue of the effect and status of human choices. Stump and Kretzmann spell out Aquinas' solution to the problem, focusing on the question of whether or not God could have failed to create. In the final analysis the answer is yes, 'there are possible worlds in which God wills not to create . . .'.³² Aquinas distinguishes between absolute necessity and conditional necessity. There are some attributes which are 'absolutely necessary' of God. He is good, He is simple, He does not do evil, and He does not make round squares. That is, He possesses His perfections necessarily and essentially, and He, necessarily, does not 'violate' His nature or the laws of logic. But there are all sorts of ways in which a perfectly good being could 'express' His perfection, and so God can choose among the different ways. No matter what, He wills the good, but He could will it differently . . . for example, through creating a different good world, or even through choosing to simply remain within the dynamic self-expression which is the Trinity. He does not 'have to' create to fulfill His nature.

But given that God is a single, simple, eternal act, what sense does it make to say that He could choose other than He does choose? In answer to this question, Aquinas is willing to admit another sort of necessity in God, conditional necessity. That is, if *x*, then *x* follows necessarily. If I am writing, then necessarily I am writing. If God eternally wills to create this world, then necessarily He eternally wills to create this world. But this does not entail any sort of 'constraint' upon God. 'Considered in the abstract, God's not creating is logically possible . . .'.³³

There are problems with this conclusion. First, while the concept of conditional necessity seems clear when applied to the activities of creatures, God's situation is so different that it seems that the same concept cannot apply, except perhaps in a *very* analogical way. When we say that it is necessary that I am writing because I am writing, but that this 'necessity' is only conditional, we have in mind a variety of qualifications with respect to 'necessity'. For example, we know that there was a time when I was not writing and so there was a time when I had the option to choose not to write. Though it is necessary that I write if I am writing I 'could have not written' and I can locate the point at which the choice to write rather than not write was made. God does what He does in His eternal moment. There was never a point at which He chose to create rather than not. From eternity He chooses to create. If the sort of necessity we ought to ascribe to

God's act of creating is less than absolute necessity, still it seems to be more than conditional necessity. Perhaps we could use the term 'actual' necessity for God's eternal and immutable act which is not an absolutely necessary consequence of His perfections and the laws of logic.

But even if we attempt to qualify the notion of conditional necessity to take account of the peculiarities of the divine situation, a problem remains. If Stump and Kretzmann have Aquinas right, there is some sense in which 'there are possible worlds in which God wills not to create . . .' But it is very difficult to see how God in the actual world could be the same being as God in some other possible world, if (1) God in the actual world is identical to His eternal and immutable act in this world, (2) God in a different possible world is identical to His act in that world, and (3) God's act in the actual world is *not* identical to His act in the other possible world. One could suppose that the principle of the transitivity of identity (if A is identical to B and B is identical to C, then A is identical to C) does not hold at the divine level across possible worlds, but I take it this entails the view that we probably can't say anything about what might be possible for God, in which case we have not solved the difficulty of distinguishing the necessary from the contingent in the divine nature.

A second possibility is to deny contingency to God. I take it that this is the move Augustine makes. Certainly God acts freely, but Augustine is a thorough-going compatibilist. Freedom means the ability to do what you want to do, what you are most drawn towards. There is nothing above and beyond God's will to constrain Him, so He is free. Could He choose other than to create? Augustine responds in the negative. In *On the Literal Meaning of Genesis* he explains that,

if He is not able to make good things then He has no power, and if He is able and does not make them, great is His envy. So because He is omnipotent and good He made all things very good.³⁴

Given God's nature He could not do other than He does. There is no contingency in God, so there are no other possible worlds, whatever we may be able to imagine.

Augustine is also a compatibilist with respect to human choices. In *The City of God* (XII, 9) and the *Unfinished Work against Julian* (V, 57) Augustine makes it very clear that if we do good it is because God has given us the grace to do so, and if we do evil it is because we are drawn back towards the nothingness from which we were made . . . because God chooses not to give us the grace necessary to avoid the downward slide. And this is the case both after and before the fall.³⁵ God is in absolute control of all that happens, there is no contingency anywhere, and so there

is no problem of reconciling contingency and necessity in a perfectly simple being.

But on Augustine's compatibilist view the problem of evil becomes acute, and it is very difficult to absolve God of the responsibility for the sin and suffering in this world. Can the simplicity of God be squared with a libertarian analysis of creaturely freedom in which rational creatures function as causal loci of their own such that they can be truly and ultimately responsible for their choices? An example will help clarify the problem. Suppose John and Mary freely commit adultery and Jane is the result of the illicit union. Since Jane exists, God knows her and sustains her in being. God's eternal, immutable act includes knowing and sustaining Jane. On the libertarian account, while God's causal activity is necessary for Jane to exist, it is not sufficient. John and Mary played an independent role without which (barring miracles) Jane would not have existed. Thus John and Mary have determined some of what will be included in God's eternal act which, on the doctrine of simplicity, is identical with His essence. What are we to make of this?

Augustine will simply deny libertarian freedom, and Aquinas may agree with this denial. At least one standard interpretation of Aquinas reads him as a compatibilist when it comes to creaturely choices.³⁶ If this is correct, and if we take Aquinas' assertion that 'God's knowledge is the cause of things' to cover even voluntary choices we will conclude that Aquinas, though allowing contingency in the divine will, does not see human choices as affecting God.³⁷ It is Anselm who insists upon libertarian freedom in creatures. He does not *define* freedom as a genuine ability to choose between open options. In fact he explicitly rejects such a definition because it cannot cover the good angels and God. He holds that God inevitably does the best and is in agreement with Augustine on the 'necessity' of God's creating the world.³⁸ God does not have literal options, but since He exists *a se* this is no limitation on Him. Creatures, though, exist through God. If we did not have literally open options we would not be responsible. We could not do evil or good. And so God has given us the great gift of allowing us to choose on our own to cling to the good that God has given us, or to throw it away. In this way we can contribute to our own creation and reflect His aseity in some small measure.³⁹ So among the philosophers in the classic tradition the task of systematizing creaturely freedom with a perfectly simple God falls to Anselm.

A first question to ask is: Since the doctrine of simplicity entails that God knows and causes in the same act, and since God is omniscient, does it follow that God somehow causes evil? Anselm answers (and here Augustine and Aquinas agree) that, oddly enough, God does not know evil. This

is because evil is not a 'thing' to be known. In the tradition in question evil is consistently analyzed as a lack or corruption of absence of good. This is the only possible answer to the question of the ontological status of evil which will jibe with the classic understanding of a Perfect Being. If God is perfect being, everything that has being is good as reflective of Him, and the 'opposite' of God is just nothing. Moreover if God's omnipotence entails that all that is is made and sustained by Him, then either He causes evil (*absurdissimus!*), or evil is nothing. Certainly there are evil choices. And whatever actually *exists* in the choice . . . the desires, the will that chooses and so on are kept in being by God. It is just in the failure to hold to the good that the will does evil, and God 'knows' that only as one would notice an empty spot where something ought to have been.⁴⁰

But this does not resolve the problems raised by contingent creaturely choices. Do such choices actually have an effect on God? If so, would this entail contingent as well as necessary attributes of God, thus denying simplicity? If not, are we left with the conclusion – rather shocking given where we started – that God's eternal and immutable nature is somehow partially 'caused' by the choices of creatures? I argued above that if God is identical to His act in this actual world, then, in some different possible world, if God* did other things, God* could not really be God. And now the problem seems much worse. On the assumption of libertarian freedom it really is up to free creatures to decide which possible world will be the actual one. But then it seems to be up to John, Mary and every free creature which version of God (If such a thing can be said!) will exist.

Before I suggest a solution it is important to get clear on 'possible worlds' talk in this context. God immutably and eternally knows and causes everything that He Himself does, and He knows everything that anyone ever has or ever will do. From the divine perspective all choices are made. (How we can reconcile this with free choice will be a major topic in Chapter 6.) Thus the actual world is at least conditionally (or in my terminology 'actually') necessary and any other world is conditionally impossible. To use the popular medieval analogy of the eternal God as the center point producing and equally present to all of the circumference of a circle which represents the temporal world, we can say that there is only one possible 'circle' since it has 'already' been drawn. Often possible worlds talk suggests that there are any number of actualizable worlds, of roughly the same ontological status, and all that distinguishes the actual world is that it just happens to be the one that got realized. Given perfect being theology this is a radically misleading way to look at things. There are other imaginable worlds, but the actual world, from God's perspective in eternity, and allowing for the input of free creaturely choices, is the only really possible world. So it is not that free

creatures pick and choose among various equally possible worlds and hence 'decide' upon which God will exist.⁴¹

And now to attempt a solution to the problem of creaturely freedom and divine simplicity. I advance this solution only tentatively and, lest it sound too radical, note that it is indeed based on premises drawn from Anselm's work. First, if creatures are free in a libertarian sense then there seems no way around holding that we do indeed have some sort of effect on God. It really is (partially) up to John and Mary that God keeps Jane in being. If God is simple, then it seems we should deny a real distinction between His obviously necessary attributes like 'being good' and His apparently contingent attributes like 'being the creator of Jane'. I say a 'real' distinction because it seems to me that we can allow an apparent one, a distinction *quoad nos*. From the human perspective, lacking the view that eternity would provide, the distinction between God's absolutely necessary attributes, 'being omniscient' and so on, and God's only conditionally or actually necessary attributes, 'being the creator of Jane' and so on, is a viable one. From God's perspective, if His essence is His eternal and immutable act in this the actual and only really possible world then He could not fail to have any of His attributes and still be Himself. They are equally necessary.⁴²

That means that we are forced to conclude that creatures do have some effect on God's very essence. This seems shocking since a major motivation for insisting on simplicity is the absolute aseity of God. And now we have apparently arrived at the conclusion that He is dependent on creatures! Anselm himself does not say this explicitly, but he does provide the key for reconciling God's aseity with His being affected by us. The operant principle comes through most clearly in *Why God Became Man*. Here Anselm claims to argue for the Incarnation through 'necessary reasons'. 'For just as in God impossibility follows upon the smallest unsuitable thing, so necessity attends the smallest reason, if it is not outweighed by a greater.'⁴³ His underlying assumption is that God, as a perfect being, must do the best. God 'must' respond to human sin by saving His creation, and He must save it in the only way God can do anything, that is, the best way. But this necessity is in no way a limitation on God. It is not a limitation because it arises from His own nature as best. The first cause in this chain of relationships is God Himself. It is not that human sin *causes* God to become incarnate. God 'must' become incarnate because He does the best because He is perfect. A similar point can be made with respect to all of God's 'reactions' to the free choices of creatures. God gives us freedom because He Himself is good. The originating cause of the whole system in which God would respond to free choices is God, and so His aseity is preserved.⁴⁴

Any systematic philosophy of God which incorporated free choice on

the part of creatures would have to hold that God is somehow affected by and responsive to something outside Himself. True, the doctrine of simplicity may require us to say that creatures affect God's very nature. But it allows us the move that this is because God chooses to set things up in this way. A denial of the doctrine leaves God dependent on various properties for His existence, and this *not* through His own choice. One can, of course, make the Augustinian move of simply denying any causal efficacy to anything outside God, but the cost is very great in that all responsibility for suffering and (apparent) evil has to be assigned to God.

I must admit that I am not at all sure that this analysis works. Even if we preserve divine independence by insisting that God is the ultimate source of the entire system which includes free choices, we may not be able to eradicate a real distinction in the nature of God between the absolute necessity of the key great-making properties and the conditional necessity of the divine attributes which involve God's response to contingent choices. Could we hold that, in the same way that God thinks many things in one thought and does many things in one act, the single divine act can encompass two kinds of necessity? Perhaps. Clearly there is more work to be done in the effort to portray a simple God who responds to human free choice. But with all its problems, the doctrine of simplicity is worth the effort. And now that we have explained and wrestled with it the rest of perfect being theology should be comparatively . . . simple.

NOTES

1. I defend the doctrine in 'The traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', reprinted as Chapter 2 of *The Anselmian Approach to God and Creation*.
2. Critics include Richard LaCroix, 'Augustine on the simplicity of God'; Alvin Plantinga, *Does God Have a Nature?*; Thomas V. Morris, 'On God and Mann: A view of divine simplicity'; Christopher Hughes, *On a Complex Theory of a Simple God*.
3. Defenders include William Mann, 'Divine simplicity', 'Simplicity and immutability in God', and 'Simplicity and properties: A reply to Morris's "On God and Mann: A view of divine simplicity"'; Eleonore Stump and Norman Kretzmann, 'Absolute simplicity'; Brian Leftow, 'Is God an abstract object?'; William Vallicella, 'Divine simplicity: A new defense'. Among the defenders, Stump and Kretzmann do offer the correct analysis of the traditional view of divine simplicity, but their article is devoted to reconciling this doctrine with the idea that God has free choice rather than to making the doctrine itself plausible.
4. Aquinas offers a number of reasons for denying corporeality to God in ST I, Q.3, arts. 1 and 2.
5. He sums up the case in Chapter 17.
6. Leftow, 'Is God an abstract object?'
7. Plantinga, *Does God Have a Nature?*, p. 34.
8. Plantinga, *Does God Have a Nature?*, pp. 52–3, for rejection of simplicity, pp. 140–6, for (tentative) conclusions.
9. For a contemporary discussion see Richard Creel, *Divine Impassibility*, Chapter 4.
10. *Commentary on the Sentences*, Book I (*Ordinatio*), Distinction II, q.4.
11. Peter Burns, SJ, 'The status and function of divine simpleness in *Summa Theologiae* Ia, qq.2–13'.
12. Burns, 'Status and function of divine simpleness in *Summa Theologiae* Ia, qq.2–13', pp. 20–6.
13. See respectively, Stump and Kretzmann, 'Absolute simplicity', pp. 376–8, and Leftow, 'Is God an abstract object?', pp. 595–6.

14. Plantinga, *Does God Have a Nature?*, p. 47.
15. The contemporary debate is rendered complicated by the fact that there is no consensus on the nature and ontological status of properties. See, for example, Mann's attack on what he terms Morris's 'lush and giddy platonism' in 'Simplicity and properties', pp. 347–51. A further difficulty is that contemporary philosophers assume uncritically that an analysis of properties as attributed to creatures can be used unmodified in speaking about God. See Hughes, *On a Complex Theory of a Simple God*, pp. 22–3.
16. Mann, 'Divine simplicity'.
17. Nicholas Wolterstorff explains that the medieval position was based on the idea that a thing's nature was a concrete thing ('Divine simplicity', see especially pp. 541–4). I argue (Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine', pp. 165–6) that this was certainly not the position of either Aquinas, to whom Wolterstorff attributes it, or in fact any but the most extreme realists.
18. ST I, Q.3, art.4. The earlier philosophers, not directly influenced by Aristotle as was Aquinas, would have tended to emphasize God's goodness rather than His being. It seems to me, though, that on the question of whether or not God just is His act of existing, the more Platonic thinkers would be in fundamental agreement with Aquinas. For Anselm see *Monologion* 16. He ends the chapter by describing God's unified nature adverbially. For God to be the highest existence, the highest life and so on is to be 'nothing other than supremely being, supremely living, and the rest'.
19. ST I, Q.4, art.1.
20. Hughes, *On a Complex Theory of a Simple God*, p. 21.
21. Hughes, *On a Complex Theory of a Simple God*, p. 27.
22. *On the Power of God*, Q.7, art.2, Objs. 6 and 9.
23. DP Q.9, art.3.
24. I have found the work of Fr W. Norris Clarke very helpful in coming to an appreciation of Aquinas' concept of being. See Clarke, *Explorations in Metaphysics*, especially Chapter 3, 'Action as the self-revelation of being: A central theme in the thought of St. Thomas'. For a defense of the Thomist position in a more analytic vein see Barry Miller, *A Most Unlikely God*, Chapters 4 and 5.
25. *The Treatise of Human Nature*, Book I, Part IV, Section 6, Personal Identity.
26. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', pp. 172–3.
27. SCG I, 55. Anselm discusses the idea that in knowing Himself God knows all things, in the *Monologion*, especially Chapter 33.
28. SCG I, 31, 3; DP Q.7, art.1.
29. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', pp. 173–4.
30. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', pp. 174–5. See, for example, Anselm's *Monologion* Chapters 33–6.
31. The view that evil is not any sort of 'thing' and is absolutely parasitic on the good is the standard medieval view. Were evil to exist as a positive property, rather than as a lack of what ought to be, then, even if it were never instantiated, it would have to come from and be dependent upon God. The view is often misunderstood in contemporary analytic philosophy of religion. See, for example, Richard Swinburne, *Providence and the Problem of Evil*, p. 32.
32. Stump and Kretzmann, 'Absolute simplicity', p. 368. ST I, Q.19, art.3.
33. Stump and Kretzmann, 'Absolute simplicity', pp. 368–9.
34. Augustine, *On the Literal Meaning of Genesis* IV, 16, 27.
35. See my, 'The irrelevance of original sin in Augustine's doctrine of the will'.
36. See for example, Etienne Gilson, *The Christian Philosophy of St. Thomas Aquinas*, pp. 244–8.
37. ST I, Q.14, art.8. Clarke, *Explorations in Metaphysics*, offers a reading of Aquinas more compatible with human responsibility. God knows our choices, not by literally causing them, nor because we produce any causal power on our own which affects God, but because He knows how His own power is channeled in our choices (pp. 205–6).
38. See my *Neoplatonic Metaphysics and Epistemology of Anselm of Canterbury*, Chapter 2.
39. *On the Fall of Satan* 18. See my 'Anselm's indeterminism'.
40. *On the Harmony of the Foreknowledge, and Predestination, and Grace of God with Free Will* I, 7.
41. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', pp. 184–5.
42. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', p. 186.
43. Anselm, *Cur Deus*, Book I, Chapter 10.
44. Rogers, 'Traditional doctrine of divine simplicity', pp. 185–6.